

Do You Know Your Premier?

A Documented Public Record of Premier Danielle Smith

All facts cited to primary sources. All allegations distinguished from findings. The record is presented in full — including actions that benefited AISH recipients.

The Alberta Disability System Breakdown — April 2026 | Background File

This document is not a polemic. It is a documented record of the Premier's public conduct — in the Legislature, before courts and commissioners, and in her public statements — that is directly relevant to the 79,000 AISH recipients whose lives are governed by decisions made by her government.

SECTION 1 — CAREER HISTORY AND POLITICAL BACKGROUND

TIMELINE	ROLE / EVENT
Born April 1, 1971	Calgary, Alberta. Second of five children. Family lived in subsidized housing. Father worked in the oil sector.
University of Calgary	Degrees in English and Economics
Late 1990s–2009	Journalist (print, radio, television); lobbyist for Canadian Federation of Independent Business
2009	Became leader of the Wildrose Party
2012 election	Led Wildrose to Official Opposition status — 17 seats. Elected to Legislature from Highwood.
November 26, 2014	Publicly condemned Wildrose colleagues for crossing the floor. Stated: <i>“there’ll be no more floor crossings.”</i>
December 17, 2014	Led mass floor crossing — herself and eight Wildrose MLAs — to the governing Progressive Conservatives. Later admitted negotiations had been ongoing for months while she was publicly condemning the act.
2015 election	Defeated in bid for PC nomination. Lost her seat.
2015–2022	Radio host, columnist, commentator

TIMELINE	ROLE / EVENT
October 6, 2022	Won UCP leadership race. Became Premier of Alberta.
May 2023	Led UCP to second consecutive majority — reduced from 63 to 49 seats.
Present	Premier and UCP leader. Next election: on or before October 18, 2027.

SECTION 2 — ETHICS COMMISSIONER FINDING: CONFIRMED BREACH OF THE CONFLICTS OF INTEREST ACT

CONFIRMED FINDING — NOT AN ALLEGATION: *On May 17, 2023, Ethics Commissioner Marguerite Trussler found that Premier Danielle Smith contravened Section 3 of the Conflicts of Interest Act. This is a documented, official finding — not an allegation.*

2.1 What Was Found

ELEMENT	DETAIL
Finding date	May 17, 2023
Finding body	Alberta Ethics Commissioner Marguerite Trussler
Provision breached	Section 3, Conflicts of Interest Act — using ministerial office to influence decisions to further the private interests of another person
Subject of Smith's intervention	Artur Pawlowski — far-right Calgary street pastor facing criminal charges under Alberta's Critical Infrastructure Defence Act related to the 2022 Coutts border blockade
What Smith did	Called Justice Minister Tyler Shandro while he was on vacation to discuss Pawlowski's charges; personally called Pawlowski and told him the charges were politically motivated; told him she contacted Crown prosecutors "almost weekly" to remind them cases had to be "winnable and in the public interest"; shared Rebel News founder Ezra Levant's letter with Shandro

ELEMENT	DETAIL
What Smith told reporters in January 2023	<i>"I've never called a Crown prosecutor. You're not allowed to do that as a politician. Everyone knows that."</i> (Jan. 14, 2023) — contradicted by recorded evidence
Response to investigation	Smith's lawyers sent a demand letter to CBC calling for retraction and apology; Smith said she was <i>"considering suing for defamation"</i>
Response after finding	Publicly apologized; UCP elected to second majority six days later

Sources: CBC News — *"Alberta Premier Smith breached Conflicts of Interest Act, says ethics commissioner"*, May 18, 2023; Global News — *"Timeline of Alberta Premier Danielle Smith and controversy over COVID court cases"*, April 11, 2023; Ethics Commissioner Marguerite Trussler — *Investigation Report*, May 17, 2023.

2.2 Additional Ethics Matters Under Investigation or Inquiry

- **Saudi Arabia trip (2024–25):** Smith accepted private flights and accommodation from the Saudi government during a trip to Saudi Arabia and the UAE. Only disclosed after direct questioning. Smith's office stated everything was cleared by the ethics commissioner. Critics noted the government had previously eased provincial ethics rules to permit politicians to more easily accept gifts under "official business" — rules changed by the same government that then relied on those changed rules as the defence.
- **Alberta Health Services restructuring (2023–ongoing):** A news leak in December 2023 revealed allegations of political interference in AHS operations, including in the hiring of Deena Hinshaw. One physician resigned in protest. A letter signed by over 200 physicians called for an investigation. The AHS procurement scandal (Section 4 of this document) is a continuation of this pattern.
- **Judicial appointments interference (January 2026):** Smith sent a letter to Prime Minister Mark Carney threatening to withhold provincial funding for new judicial appointments unless Alberta received more say in selecting judges for the Court of King's Bench, the Alberta Court of Appeal, and the Court of Justice. Legal scholars described this as constitutionally problematic.

Sources: Ethics Commissioner Trussler report, May 2023; *Prairie Exposed Substack* — *"Power, Privilege, and Secrecy: Inside Danielle Smith's Alberta"*, March 2026.

SECTION 3 — DOCUMENTED CONDUCT PATTERN: STATEMENTS AND ACTIONS

3.1 The Floor Crossing — A Documented Sequence

The floor crossing of December 17, 2014 is significant not only as a political event but as a documented sequence of contradictory public statements.

DATE	STATEMENT OR ACTION
November 26, 2014	Smith publicly condemned two Wildrose colleagues for crossing the floor. Stated: <i>“there’ll be no more floor crossings.”</i> Made public statements of outrage at the act she was simultaneously planning.
December 17, 2014	Smith led herself and eight Wildrose MLAs across the floor to the governing PCs — the leader of the Official Opposition joining the government, unprecedented in Canadian federal or provincial history. She took 440,000+ Wildrose voters’ representation with her.
Subsequent admission	Smith later admitted that negotiations with PC Premier Jim Prentice had been ongoing for months — including during the period she was publicly condemning floor crossings. She knew she was planning to do exactly what she was publicly condemning others for doing.
Smith’s own explanation	<i>“If you’re going to be the official Opposition leader, you have to really want to take down the government and really take down the premier. I don’t want to take down this premier. I want this premier to succeed.”</i>
Outcome	The mass floor crossing is widely credited as a direct cause of the 2015 election of Alberta’s first NDP government under Rachel Notley.

Sources: Wikipedia — Danielle Smith; The Canadian Encyclopedia — Danielle Smith; Dave Berta political blog, December 2014.

3.2 Unsubstantiated Indigenous Heritage Claims

CLAIM / EVENT	FINDING / RESPONSE
2012 — Legislature	Smith invoked her <i>“great-great-grandmother”</i> being a member of the Cherokee Nation, forcibly removed on the Trail of Tears, to claim personal connection to Indigenous oppression.
September 28, 2022 — UCP leadership campaign	Smith tweeted: <i>“As someone with Indigenous ancestry, I honour the heritage of Canada’s Indigenous Peoples as one of our nation’s and province’s greatest treasures and strengths.”</i>

CLAIM / EVENT	FINDING / RESPONSE
November 2022 — APTN investigation	APTN News worked with Canadian and Cherokee genealogists and examined U.S. census reports from the late 1800s. No evidence of Cherokee ancestry found. Smith's claimed ancestor (Mary Frances Crowe) was born in Georgia in 1870 — two decades after the Trail of Tears removal. Smith's ancestors do not appear on the Dawes Roll — the U.S. registry cataloguing members of the Cherokee, Creek, Choctaw, Chickasaw and Seminole nations.
Cherokee genealogist Kathy Griffin	<i>"It's not unusual for settlers from Tennessee, Oklahoma, or Kansas to claim some Cherokee ancestry."</i> — Griffin could find no proof that any of Smith's ancestors were members of any of the three federally recognized Cherokee tribes.
Smith's office response	<i>"Smith hasn't done a deep dive into her ancestry but is proud of her roots."</i> No substantive response to APTN's specific genealogical findings.
Response from Indigenous leaders	At a press conference of Treaties 6, 7 and 8 leaders, the room broke into laughter when Smith's heritage claims were raised. Chief Tony Alexis of Alexis Nakota Sioux Nation: <i>"A true Indigenous person would not go against all the treaty people of this land."</i>
August 2025	Smith was photographed wearing a traditional First Nations ribbon skirt, receiving criticism from Indigenous community members who regard the garment as sacred.

Sources: APTN News — *"Danielle Smith says she has Cherokee roots, but there's no record of them"*, November 2022; CBC News — *"First Nations chief critical of Alberta Premier Danielle Smith's Indigenous heritage claim"*, November 18, 2022.

3.3 Public Health Misinformation — Documented Record

STATEMENT / ACTION	DATE	SOURCE
Stated the unvaccinated were <i>"the most discriminated against group that I have ever witnessed in my lifetime"</i>	October 11, 2022 (first press conference as Premier)	CBC News, October 2022

STATEMENT / ACTION	DATE	SOURCE
Compared COVID vaccinated Albertans to “followers of Adolf Hitler” / invoked Nuremberg Code in relation to COVID vaccine mandates	November 10, 2021 (as Wildrose leader candidate)	Global News; National Observer — Smith apologized May 2023
Stated “moderate cigarette consumption can reduce the risk of COVID-19”	Documented in Canadian Encyclopedia biography	The Canadian Encyclopedia — Danielle Smith
Promoted ivermectin as a treatment for COVID-19 and hydroxychloroquine as a cure	2020–2021 period	The Canadian Encyclopedia
Boycotted wearing the Remembrance Day poppy to protest public health measures	November 2021	Wikipedia — Danielle Smith
Questioned legitimacy of reports of unmarked graves found at residential schools (social media posts on Locals.com)	2021	Wikipedia — Danielle Smith
Expressed support for the Freedom Convoy blockades including the Coutts border crossing	Early 2022	The Canadian Encyclopedia

SECTION 4 — ALBERTA HEALTH SERVICES PROCUREMENT SCANDAL (ACTIVE — RCMP INVESTIGATION ONGOING)

IMPORTANT DISTINCTION: *The allegations in Section 4 have NOT been proven in court. They are documented as allegations from a lawsuit and related investigations. The RCMP investigation is ongoing. Smith and her government deny wrongdoing. These facts are presented because they are publicly documented, the RCMP has confirmed an active investigation, and they are directly relevant to understanding the government's priorities in health administration.*

4.1 The Sequence of Events

DATE	EVENT
2022	MHCare Medical (owner: Sam Mraiche) awarded \$70M contract to import children's pain medication from Turkey during national shortage. Alberta received ~30% of order despite paying full price. The medication received was later withdrawn for safety concerns.
2023–2024	Mraiche provided luxury Edmonton Oilers box seats to multiple cabinet ministers and senior staff in Smith's office. Globe and Mail later reported Mraiche was present in Smith's inner-circle election night suite in 2023. Government eased ethics rules in 2023 making it easier to accept such gifts under "official business."
December 2023	Athana Mentzelopoulos appointed CEO of Alberta Health Services. She launched an internal investigation into AHS procurement, specifically into contracts with private surgical facilities and MHCare-related companies — totalling approximately \$614 million.
December 19, 2023	Mentzelopoulos briefed the AHS Board on her investigation. The Board recommended expanding the investigation and that she consider taking findings to the RCMP.
January 8, 2025	Mentzelopoulos was terminated as AHS CEO — two days before she was scheduled to meet with the Auditor General to discuss her investigation.
January 31, 2025	The entire AHS Board of Directors — which had recommended taking the findings to the RCMP — was dismissed by the government.
February 6, 2025	Globe and Mail reported Mentzelopoulos's lawyer's letter alleging she was fired for investigating. Letter alleged Smith's then-chief of staff Marshall Smith pressured her to approve contracts; that an AHS procurement official had a MHCare email account while negotiating the children's medication contract; and that Marshall Smith told her he "would be taken care of for the rest of his life" in relation to "Sam" (Mraiche).
February 2025	RCMP received a complaint relating to AHS. Mentzelopoulos filed wrongful dismissal lawsuit.

DATE	EVENT
March 2025	RCMP confirmed active investigation and execution of multiple search warrants.
March 2026	RCMP searched MHCare's Edmonton offices. RCMP confirmed ongoing investigation. Mentzelopoulos wrongful dismissal suit continues. Smith's government denied all wrongdoing throughout.

Sources: *Globe and Mail* — “Alberta ousted health services CEO amid probe into medical contracts”, February 6, 2025; *CBC News* — “Former AHS CEO’s lawsuit alleges pressure to sign private surgery deals”, February 14, 2025; *Global News* — “RCMP search MHCare”, March 2026; *The Tyee* — “Health Care Corruption Allegations Rock Smith Government”, February 7, 2025. All allegations unproven in court.

4.2 What the AISH Community Should Understand About This Scandal

The AHS scandal involves hundreds of millions of dollars in health procurement contracts directed to companies with documented ties to government insiders, under a government that simultaneously:

- Cut AISH by \$49 million over three years.
- Clawed back \$190 million/year in federal Canada Disability Benefit funding.
- Cut homelessness funding by \$4 million.
- Cut disability advocacy organizations including Voices of Albertans with Disabilities.
- Raised community housing rent by 63% for the most vulnerable recipients.

The question of fiscal necessity — which the government uses to justify disability income restructuring — is directly undermined by a documented record of hundreds of millions of dollars in health procurement with politically connected contractors, under a government that eased its own ethics rules to make the gift relationships that facilitated those contracts easier to maintain.

SECTION 5 — THE AISH AND DISABILITY RECORD: THE FULL PICTURE

The AISH community's frustration with Premier Smith is documented and substantiated. But the record is not one-dimensional. It includes both a significant positive decision early in her tenure and a sustained pattern of decisions — and public statements — that have materially harmed the same population.

5.1 What Smith Did For AISH (Credit Where Due)

ACTION	DATE	IMPACT
Re-indexed AISH to the Consumer Price Index	November 2022 announcement — effective January 1, 2023	Reversed the Kenney government's 2019 de-indexation, which had cost recipients purchasing power for four years. The University of Calgary found de-indexation had cost Albertans \$118.6 million more in taxes in 2020 alone. Re-indexation was a meaningful improvement for ~70,000 recipients at the time.

5.2 What Smith's Government Did Against AISH — The Documented Record

DECISION	DATE	IMPACT
Freeze on new AISH applications — caseworker positions cut	2023–2024	AUPE president Sandra Azocar (February 2024): <i>"People with disabilities are tired of waiting to be assessed and to get support. Some have been waiting for more than two years because the government has instituted a freeze on handling new applications. The government has axed the jobs of dozens of case workers and is refusing to fill vacant positions."</i>
Clawback of federal Canada Disability Benefit — dollar-for-dollar	Announced July 2025 — effective September 2025	Alberta is the only province or territory in Canada to claw back the CDB. Net benefit to AISH recipients: \$0. Net saving to Alberta government: ~\$190 million/year. Every other province exempts the CDB.
AISH cut by \$49 million	Budget 2025 — 2025-26 fiscal year	Direct reduction to program funding for 79,000 recipients.
Community housing rent increase — 63% by ministerial order	October 2025	+\$221/month for recipients in community housing — their last affordable housing option.

DECISION	DATE	IMPACT
ADAP transition — Bill 12 passed	December 9, 2025	Creates mandatory transition of all AISH recipients to ADAP effective July 1, 2026. Base benefit \$200/month lower than AISH after transition benefit expires December 31, 2027. Employment exemption cut from \$1,072 to \$700 (ADAP) or \$350 (new AISH). Removes cost-of-living indexing from legislation. Removes independent appeal rights.
Cut disability advocacy organizations	January 2025	Voices of Albertans with Disabilities and Centre to Empower All Survivors of Exploitation and Trafficking defunded under “merit-based programming” mandate.
Homelessness funding cut	2025-26 budget	\$4 million reduction — with further cuts projected.

5.3 What Smith Said Publicly About AISH Recipients — On the Record

STATEMENT	DATE	CONTEXT AND RESPONSE
Said AISH was “<i>not overly generous</i>” — then said she wants to ensure programs like AISH “<i>aren’t overly generous</i>”	March 2026	CBC News reported: “ <i>The premier said her government wants to ensure programs like Assured Income for the Severely Handicapped, or AISH, aren’t ‘overly generous.’</i> ” AISH pays \$1,940/month — below the poverty line in every major Alberta city.

STATEMENT	DATE	CONTEXT AND RESPONSE
Claimed people are moving to Alberta specifically to access AISH — without providing evidence	March 6, 2026	CBC Calgary asked Smith's office how many people have moved to Alberta to access AISH. No answer was received. Inclusion Alberta CEO Trish Bowman: <i>"We previously asked the province for evidence people are moving to Alberta to access AISH, but have not received data backing up this argument. If we're going to be making social policy that affects tens of thousands of Albertans, it should be based on evidence."</i> NDP MLA Marie Renaud: <i>"People don't move here to live in the lap of luxury of AISH or to wait five years for a PDD contract."</i>
On her call-in radio show	March 2026	Multiple AISH recipients called in with accounts of hardship under the ADAP transition. Smith acknowledged the issues and <i>"hinted at potential adjustments."</i> No policy changes followed.

Sources: CBC News — "Advocates push back on Danielle Smith's comment that people are moving to Alberta for social programs", March 6-7, 2026; AUPE statement, February 2024; Inclusion Alberta — ADAP fact sheets, October and December 2025; People's Voice — "Alberta's cuts to disability support", May 2025.

5.4 The Answer to the Community's Question

The AISH community's frustration with Premier Smith is not based on feeling attacked by her existence. It is based on a documented sequence:

- She re-indexed AISH in 2023 — a genuine improvement.
- Then her government clawed back the federal CDB — uniquely in Canada — returning net benefit to recipients: \$0.
- Then cut AISH by \$49 million.
- Then raised housing costs by 63% for the same population.
- Then passed Bill 12 removing \$200/month, the employment exemption, cost-of-living indexing, and independent appeal rights.
- Then cut disability advocacy organizations that helped recipients navigate those changes.

- Then said AISH might be “*overly generous*” without evidence.
- Then claimed people are moving to Alberta for AISH — without being able to provide a single data point when asked.
- All while her government awarded hundreds of millions of dollars in health procurement contracts to companies with documented ties to government insiders, under eased ethics rules, with an active RCMP investigation now underway.

*The re-indexation was real. So is everything that followed it. **The question the AISH community is asking is not irrational. It is: why was the re-indexation given with one hand and then taken back — and more — with the other?** The documented record does not provide an answer grounded in fiscal necessity. It provides an answer grounded in political priority.*

SECTION 6 — SUMMARY OF DOCUMENTED RECORD

CATEGORY	DOCUMENTED FACT
Ethics Commissioner finding	Section 3 breach of Conflicts of Interest Act — May 17, 2023. Confirmed finding.
Floor crossing	December 17, 2014 — Publicly condemned floor crossings while secretly negotiating one. Unprecedented in Canadian history.
Indigenous heritage claims	Claimed Cherokee ancestry in Legislature (2012) and UCP leadership race (2022). APTN investigation found no genealogical evidence. Smith’s ancestors do not appear on the Dawes Roll.
Public health misinformation	Documented statements comparing vaccinated to Nazi followers; promoting ivermectin; calling unvaccinated “ <i>most discriminated against group</i> ”; questioning residential school unmarked graves.
AHS procurement scandal	Former AHS CEO fired two days before Auditor General meeting. Entire board dismissed. RCMP active investigation confirmed. \$614 million in contracts to politically connected firms alleged. Unproven in court.
Saudi Arabia	Accepted private flights and accommodation from Saudi government. Disclosed only under direct questioning. Defended as cleared under ethics rules — rules the government had previously changed.

CATEGORY	DOCUMENTED FACT
AISH — positive decision	Re-indexed AISH to CPI — effective January 2023. Reversed Kenney's 2019 de-indexation.
AISH — subsequent decisions	CDB clawback (unique to Alberta, \$190M/year); \$49M AISH cut; 63% housing rent increase; ADAP transition (\$200/month cut, exemption slashed, appeal rights removed); disability advocacy defunded; homelessness funding cut.
Public statements about AISH	<i>"Not overly generous" / "aren't overly generous"</i> (March 2026); claimed people moving to Alberta for AISH without data to support it (March 2026).

SOURCES AND REFERENCES

- Wikipedia — Danielle Smith (accessed April 2026)
- The Canadian Encyclopedia — Danielle Smith
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The Alberta Disability System Breakdown — Advocate

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Find the public group on Facebook: facebook.com/share/g/1CrU5PfHha/